

Homewise VOC Interview Notes #1

Screenener

Have you hired a contractor before?

Yes.

Roughly what did the project cost?

- Large remodel (~\$60,000): flooring replacement, interior painting, kitchen cabinets
- Small repairs and yearly maintenance (\$100–\$1,000): gutter, lawn, roofing, irrigation, painting, dryer vent cleaning, tree removal
- Example: electrician visit for flickering lights cost \$450 (home warranty covered \$250). The work only took about 40 minutes, which felt overpriced

Do you own your home?

Yes.

Home warranty details

- ~\$700–800 per year
- Requires deductible
- Covers part of the cost

Warm-up

Tell me about your home and how often you hire contractors.

Owned the home for 4 years. Hires contractors multiple times per year.

Experience includes both:

- Maintenance work (recurring, smaller scope)
- Remodel projects (especially after moving in)

Recent Experience (Anchored Case)

Walk me through the last time you hired a contractor.

Sliding siding replacement due to rotting siding (identified by family member).

Discovery and Selection

How did you find contractors? What sources did you use?

Used Yelp, Angi, and referrals from friends.

Referrals are not always reliable.

How did you decide which ones to contact? What made you rule some out?

Looked for:

- High ratings
- Large number of reviews

Ruled out:

- Contractors with negative reviews

Quote Comparison

How many quotes did you get? How did you compare them?

- Reached out to 10 contractors and received 7 quotes

Quotes varied significantly in both **price and scope**:

- Handyman repair (partial patch): ~\$250
- Mid-range options: \$400–900 (some include diagnosis)
- Full replacement (8 panels + underlying layers): ~\$7,000

Key challenge: “Apples to oranges” comparison

- Different contractors propose fundamentally different scopes
- Large contractors:
 - Provide detailed, itemized breakdowns (e.g., number of paint layers, defined steps)
- Smaller contractors / handymen:
 - Provide lump sum pricing with minimal detail

Result:

- Quotes are not directly comparable
- No consistent baseline across contractors

User questions:

- Is the handyman oversimplifying the issue?
- Is the larger contractor over-scoping to increase revenue?

Current approach:

- Attempts to use AI to interpret and compare quotes
- Finds outputs ambiguous and not actionable

Pricing Understanding

How did you know if the price was fair?

Did not know. This is the biggest challenge.

Additional insight:

- Price cannot be evaluated independently from scope
- Without a standardized scope, pricing comparison is unreliable

Trust and Verification

What did you do to check if contractors were licensed, insured, or reputable?

- Checked license, insurance, and bond via websites (Asked AI for suggestions on the websites.)

Scheduling and Execution

How did scheduling and the actual work go?

Scheduling was not a major issue.

Post-Project

What happened after the work was done (paperwork, receipts, warranties)?

Received documentation via email and kept track of it.

Not a pain point.

Reuse and Referral

If you find someone trustworthy, would you hire them again?

Yes.

Would you refer them to others?

Yes.

Pain Points

What was the most frustrating part of the experience?

1. Scope Uncertainty (Primary Issue)

- Core problem across most projects
- Contractors propose different methods and levels of intervention
- No way to validate which approach is correct or necessary

Example (siding case):

- Patch vs partial replacement vs full replacement vs structural repair
- Leads to large price variation (\$250 to \$7,000)

2. “Apples to Oranges” Comparison

- Quotes differ in both **scope and level of detail**
- Large contractors:
 - Provide detailed breakdowns
- Smaller contractors:
 - Provide lump sum pricing

Result:

- Cannot compare quotes directly
- Unclear what is included or excluded

3. Hidden Scope Complexity (Remodel Example)

Example: Cabinet painting

- User assumed simple repainting
- Issue:
 - Existing paint was oil-based
 - New paint was water-based
- Result:
 - Required sanding before repainting
 - Additional cost introduced

Insight:

- Critical scope requirements were not identified upfront
- Leads to rework and unexpected costs

4. Lack of Construction Method Validation

- Multiple valid construction methods exist/proposed by contractors
- User cannot evaluate:
 - Whether the method is appropriate
 - Whether it is necessary or excessive

5. Decision-Making Difficulty

- Even with multiple quotes, user cannot confidently decide
- Missing:
 - Standardized scope
 - Trusted expert validation

6. Pattern Recognition by User

- For simple, standardized tasks (e.g., gutter cleaning, fence painting, landscaping):
 - Scope is clear
 - Pricing is predictable
 - Experience is smooth
- For complex or diagnostic tasks:

- Scope is unclear
- Quotes vary widely
- Experience becomes difficult

Desired Improvements

If you could change one thing about hiring a contractor, what would it be?

This homeowner wishes to hire an experienced professional (e.g., electrician, plumber) with 10+ years of experience

- This person would:
 - Diagnose the issue only
 - Not perform the actual work
 - Provide a clear scope of work

Possible workflow:

1. On-site inspection (may require accessing hidden conditions)
2. Collect data (photos, observations)
3. Use AI to:
 - Analyze the issue
 - Compare possible methods
 - Generate or validate scope

Goal:

- Use the defined scope to request comparable quotes

This homeowner also identified Challenges with his Approach:

- Professionals may not want to be paid only for diagnosis
- Homeowners may resist paying upfront for diagnosis
- Contractors may not want to follow externally defined scope
- Multiple valid methods make standardization difficult

Conclusion:

- Conceptually strong, but difficult to implement due to market behavior

Existing Solutions / Market Signals

Did you see any similar solutions or ideas in the market?

Participant mentioned a friend who built a product targeting this problem.

Product Approach Observed

- Focuses only on **highly standardized tasks**, such as:
 - Gutter cleaning
 - Fence painting

Reason:

- These tasks have clearly defined scope (e.g., length, area, quantity)
- Easier to standardize pricing and comparison

Business Signal

- The product is reportedly being used
- Users are paying for it (estimated at a few thousand dollars per month, not verified)

Insight

- Confirms that:
 - The problem is real and recognized
 - Current viable solutions focus on **narrow, standardized categories**
- Suggests:
 - Scaling to complex, diagnostic tasks remains unsolved

Business Model Consideration

Who should pay for this type of solution?

Initial assumption:

- Homeowners pay via subscription

Interview participant's perspective:

- More likely that **contractors pay**, not homeowners

Reasoning:

- Homeowners are less willing to pay upfront
- Contractors already pay for lead generation platforms (e.g., Angi)
- Aligns with existing marketplace models

Current Workarounds

Is there anything you do today to make hiring contractors easier?

The interview participant uses AI to:

- Identify issues
- Explore possible solutions

Limitation:

- AI is not yet reliable for:
 - Diagnosis
 - Scope definition
 - Decision-making

Wrap-up

How would you describe the overall experience?

Painful.

Additional notes / opportunities mentioned by participant

- Strong need for scope standardization before hiring
- Interest in tools that help validate and define scope
- Standardized task categories may be a practical starting point
- Larger opportunity exists in solving complex, diagnostic scenarios